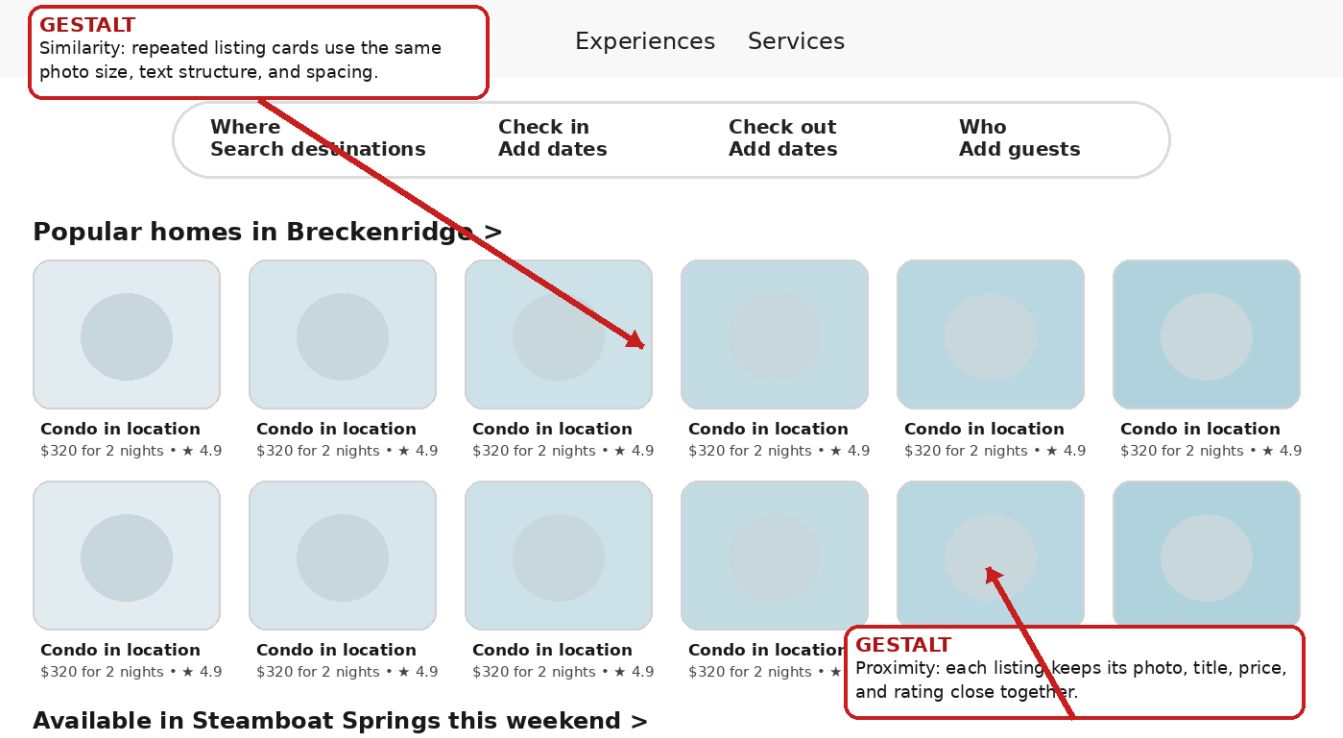
Gestalt Principles: Effective vs. Ineffective Websites

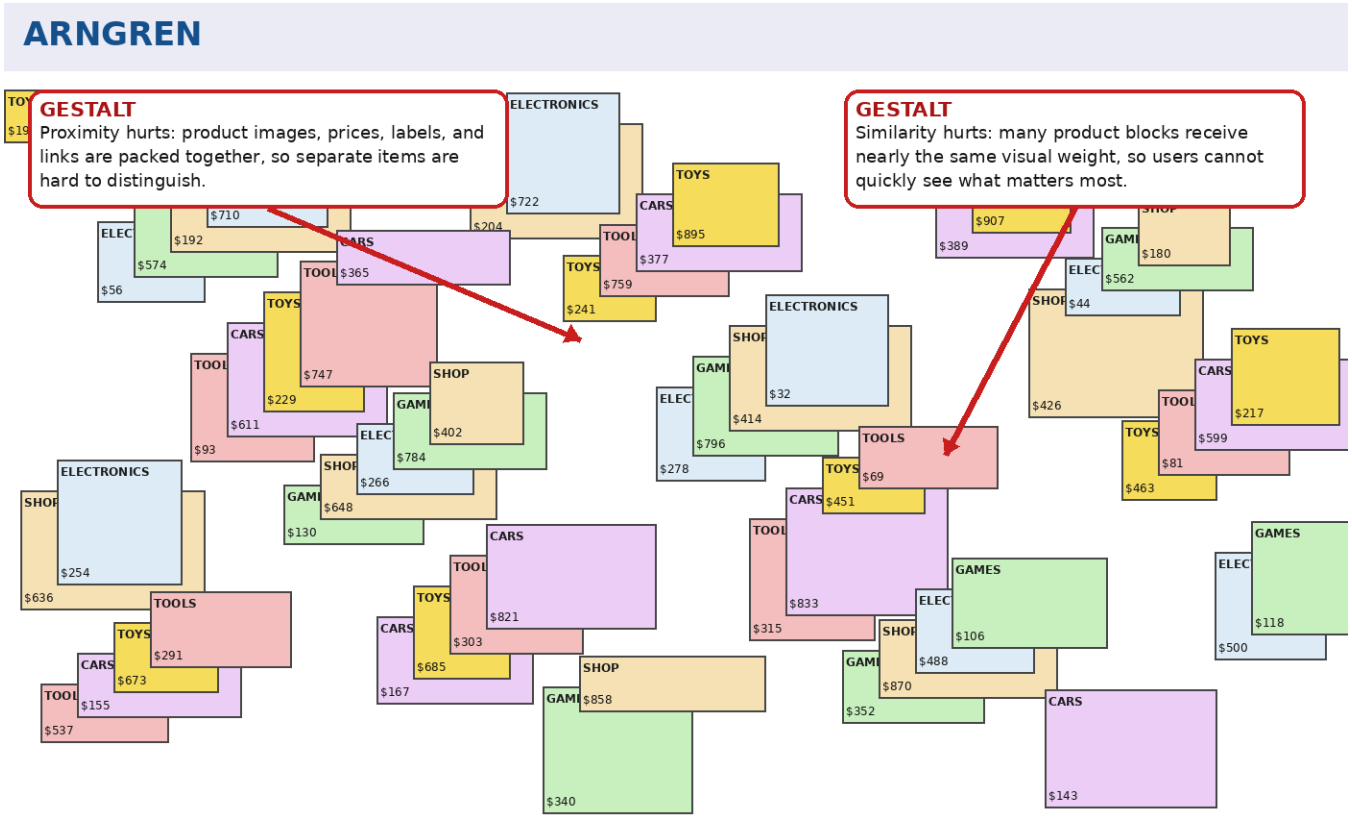
Website 1: Airbnb — Effective Use of Gestalt



Annotated visual reference based on the Airbnb homepage/listing-card layout. Source: Airbnb homepage and current interface references. ■cite■turn1search0■turn1search9■

Site selection and justification: I chose Airbnb as the effective example because its homepage is designed around a clear task: helping users discover and compare places to stay. The repeated listing-card structure gives users a predictable way to scan information. Airbnb's current homepage includes a search area followed by organized categories and destination-based content, while its property cards consistently combine photos, location information, ratings, and prices. ■cite■turn1search0■turn1search9■ The first Gestalt principle is **Proximity**. Information that belongs to one listing is placed close together. A user can see the property photo, title, location, price, and rating as one group instead of having to connect information spread across the page. This makes comparison faster and lowers the amount of mental effort required to understand each option. The spacing between different cards also helps users recognize where one listing ends and another begins. The second principle is **Similarity**. Airbnb repeats the same basic visual pattern across its listings: large image, small supporting information, price, and rating. Similarity causes users to recognize these cards as items with the same purpose. Once a user learns how one card works, the same pattern can be applied to every other card. This improves learnability and makes the page feel predictable. Overall, Airbnb's use of Gestalt principles supports a smooth browsing experience. The page does not need heavy borders or long instructions to explain how its content is organized. Users can visually understand the relationships between elements almost immediately. That makes Airbnb an effective example because its visual organization supports the site's main goal instead of competing with it.

Website 2: Arngren.net — Ineffective Use of Gestalt



Annotated visual reference based on documented Arngren homepage screenshots. Source: Web Design Museum and design analyses of Arngren. ■cite■turn2search3■turn0search1■

Site selection and justification: I chose Arngren.net as the ineffective example because its homepage is famous for displaying a very large number of products, prices, images, and links with little visual organization. Web-design sources describe the site as extremely cluttered, with products packed across the page and weak visual hierarchy. ■cite■turn2search1■turn0search1■ This makes it a strong example for showing how Gestalt principles can hurt usability when grouping and visual similarity are not controlled. The first principle is **Proximity**. On Arngren, product images, labels, prices, and links are often positioned very close together. Proximity normally tells users that nearby elements belong together, but the excessive density makes it difficult to determine where one product ends and another starts. Users have to spend more time scanning the page to identify which information belongs to which item. That increases cognitive load and makes shopping less efficient. The second principle is **Similarity**. Many product blocks use similar visual weight and styling, while different categories compete for attention at the same time. Similarity can help users recognize related items, but when too many unrelated elements look equally important, the principle stops creating useful hierarchy. The user has no obvious visual starting point. Overall, Arngren's design makes users work too hard to understand the page. A cleaner grid, stronger spacing, clearer categories, and more distinct visual levels would make the site easier to scan. The problem is not simply that the site contains many products; the problem is that the visual relationships do not guide the user effectively.

Sources

Airbnb homepage: https://www.airbnb.com/ ■cite■turn1search0■

Interaction Design Foundation — Gestalt Principles: https://www.interaction-design.org/literature/topics/gestalt-principles ■cite■turn0search9■

Web Design Museum — Arngren in 2003: https://www.webdesignmuseum.org/gallery/arngren-in-2003 ■cite■turn2search3■

DesignRush — Bad Website Design Examples: https://www.designrush.com/agency/website-design-development/trends/bad-websites ■cite■turn0search1■